The Rise of Nationalism in Europe

The big idea

Before the 1800s, Europe was not a map of "nation-states". It was a patchwork of kingdoms, duchies and multi-ethnic empires ruled by dynasties. People felt loyal to a king or a region, not to a "nation". This chapter shows how the idea that **people who share a language, culture and history should have their own state** spread across Europe in the nineteenth century, and how it built new countries like **Italy** and **Germany**.

NATION-STATE

A state in which the majority of citizens (not only rulers) develop a sense of **common identity and shared history or descent**. This identity is created through struggles, the actions of leaders and common people.

In 1848 the French artist **Frédéric Sorrieu** made a set of four prints showing his dream of a world of "democratic and social republics". Peoples of Europe and America march past the Statue of Liberty, offering homage; the shattered symbols of absolutism lie in the dust. It is a picture of the hope this chapter is about.

The French Revolution and the idea of the nation

The first clear expression of nationalism came with the **French Revolution of 1789**. Sovereignty moved from the monarch to the **people**. The revolutionaries built a collective identity through:

- the ideas of **la patrie** (the fatherland) and **le citoyen** (the citizen)
- a new **tricolour flag** replacing the royal standard

- the **Estates General** renamed the **National Assembly**, elected by active citizens
- new hymns, oaths and martyrs commemorated in the name of the nation
- a centralised administration, uniform laws, abolition of internal customs duties, and a **uniform system of weights and measures**
- **French** promoted as the common language; regional dialects discouraged

Napoleon destroyed democracy in France but made administration rational and efficient. His **Civil Code of 1804** (the **Napoleonic Code**) abolished privileges based on birth, established equality before the law and secured the right to property. He simplified administrative divisions, abolished the feudal system and freed peasants from serfdom and manorial dues. In towns, guild restrictions were removed, and transport and communication improved. But soon people in conquered areas turned hostile because of higher taxes, censorship and forced conscription into French armies.

The making of nationalism in Europe

In the early 1800s, the **aristocracy** was socially and politically dominant, while a growing **middle class** of industrialists, businessmen and professionals pushed for national unity.

LIBERALISM

From the Latin *liber*, meaning free. For the middle classes it meant **freedom for the individual and equality before the law**, government by consent, a constitution and representative government. Economically it meant **freedom of markets** and abolition of state restrictions on movement of goods and capital.

In 1834 a customs union or **Zollverein** was formed at the initiative of **Prussia** and joined by most German states. It abolished tariff barriers and reduced the number of currencies from over thirty to two. The railways further stimulated a sense of economic national unity.

A new conservatism after 1815. After Napoleon's defeat in 1815, European governments followed **conservatism**, believing that traditional institutions (monarchy, Church, social hierarchies, property, family) should be preserved. At the **Congress of Vienna (1815)**, hosted by the Austrian Chancellor **Duke Metternich**, the Treaty of Vienna undid most changes of the Napoleonic wars: the Bourbon dynasty was restored in France, and states were set up on France's borders to prevent future expansion. Censorship laws controlled newspapers and books.

The revolutionaries. Secret societies trained revolutionaries. **Giuseppe Mazzini**, born in Genoa in 1807, founded **Young Italy** in Marseilles and **Young Europe** in Berne. Metternich called him "the most dangerous enemy of our social order".

The age of revolutions (1830–1848).

- **July 1830**: in France, the Bourbon kings were overthrown and a constitutional monarchy with **Louis Philippe** at its head was installed. Metternich once remarked, "When France sneezes, the rest of Europe catches cold."
- **Greek war of independence (from 1821)**: Greece had been part of the **Ottoman Empire**. Poets and artists hailed Greece as the cradle of European civilisation; the English poet **Lord Byron** died in the war in 1824. The **Treaty of Constantinople (1832)** recognised Greece as an independent nation.

The romantic imagination. Romanticism was a cultural movement that used art, poetry, stories and music to build a feeling of a shared collective heritage. The German philosopher **Johann Gottfried Herder** claimed that true German culture was to be discovered among the common people, *das volk*, through folk songs, folk poetry and folk dances. The **Grimm brothers** collected folktales. In **Poland**, partitioned among Russia, Prussia and Austria, nationalism was kept alive through music and language; **Karol Kurpinski** celebrated the national struggle through operas and polonaise and mazurka folk dances. Using Polish in Church gatherings became a symbol of struggle against Russian dominance.

Hunger, hardship and 1848. The 1830s were years of economic hardship. In 1845, weavers in **Silesia** revolted against contractors who had drastically reduced payments. In 1848, food shortages and unemployment brought Paris

onto the roads; Louis Philippe fled, and a republic was proclaimed with suffrage to all adult males above 21.

The 1848 revolution of the liberals. In the German regions, elected representatives met in the **Frankfurt Parliament** on **18 May 1848** in the Church of St Paul: 831 representatives drafted a constitution for a German nation headed by a monarchy subject to a parliament. When they offered the crown to **Friedrich Wilhelm IV, King of Prussia**, he rejected it, and the parliament was dissolved. Its social base was mostly middle class, it resisted workers' and women's demands (women were only allowed to watch from the visitors' gallery), so it lost popular support.

Unification of Germany and Italy

GERMANY: "BLOOD AND IRON" (1871)

After 1848, nationalism moved away from democracy and revolution. **Prussia** took leadership of German unification. Its chief minister **Otto von Bismarck** carried out the process with the help of the Prussian army and bureaucracy. **Three wars over seven years**, with **Austria, Denmark and France**, ended in Prussian victory. In **January 1871**, the Prussian king **William I** was proclaimed **German Emperor** in a ceremony at **Versailles** (the Hall of Mirrors).

ITALY (1861)

Italy was divided into **seven states**; only **Sardinia–Piedmont** was ruled by an Italian princely house. The north was under the Austrian Habsburgs, the centre under the Pope, and the south under the Bourbon kings of Spain.

- **Mazzini** had tried to build a unitary Italian republic (Young Italy), but uprisings in 1831 and 1848 failed.
- **King Victor Emmanuel II** of Sardinia-Piedmont took the lead. Chief Minister **Count Cavour** made a diplomatic alliance with France and defeated the Austrian forces in 1859.

- In **1860**, **Giuseppe Garibaldi** led his volunteers, the **Red Shirts**, into South Italy and the **Kingdom of the Two Sicilies**, driving out the Spanish rulers.
- In **1861**, **Victor Emmanuel II** was proclaimed **king of united Italy**.

The strange case of Britain. In Britain, nation-state formation was not a sudden upheaval but a long process. The **Act of Union (1707)** between England and Scotland created the United Kingdom of Great Britain, in effect letting England dominate Scotland. **Ireland** was forcibly incorporated in **1801**. A new "British nation" was forged by propagating a dominant English culture: the British flag (Union Jack), the national anthem (God Save Our Noble King) and the English language.

Visualising the nation

Artists personified nations as female figures, giving an abstract idea a concrete form. **Marianne** represented France (red cap, tricolour, cockade) and **Germania** represented Germany.

Symbol (in Philip Veit's Germania)	Meaning
Broken chains	Being freed
Breastplate with eagle	Symbol of the German empire: strength
Crown of oak leaves	Heroism
Sword	Readiness to fight
Olive branch around the sword	Willingness to make peace
Black, red and gold tricolour	Flag of the liberal-nationalists in 1848
Rays of the rising sun	Beginning of a new era

Nationalism and imperialism

By the last quarter of the nineteenth century, nationalism became narrow and aggressive. The **Balkans** (modern Romania, Bulgaria, Albania, Greece, Macedonia, Croatia, Bosnia-Herzegovina, Slovenia, Serbia and Montenegro), inhabited by people broadly called **Slavs**, were under the Ottoman Empire. As Ottoman power declined, Balkan states fought one another and big powers (Russia, Germany, England, Austro-Hungary) competed for control. The region became a "**powder keg**", and this rivalry led to the **First World War in 1914**. Anti-imperial movements in colonies later borrowed the idea of the nation-state.

MIXING UP THE UNIFIERS

Mazzini = Young Italy (revolutionary idealist). Cavour = diplomat and chief minister of Sardinia-Piedmont. Garibaldi = Red Shirts, conquered the South. Bismarck = Germany, not Italy.

BOARD FAVOURITES

"Describe the process of unification of Germany/Italy" (5 marks), "Measures taken by French revolutionaries to create a collective identity", "Napoleonic Code: main features", and "Role of culture (Romanticism) in nationalism". Write each as numbered value points.

Quick recap

- 1789 French Revolution: la patrie, le citoyen, tricolour, National Assembly.
- 1804 Napoleonic Code: equality before law, right to property, end of feudalism.
- 1815 Congress of Vienna (Metternich) restored conservative regimes.
- 1834 Zollverein; 1832 Treaty of Constantinople (Greece independent); 1848 Frankfurt Parliament.
- Italy unified 1861 (Victor Emmanuel II, Cavour, Garibaldi); Germany 1871 (Bismarck, William I).

- Marianne (France), Germania (Germany); Balkans became the powder keg of Europe.

Practice questions

1. Which of the following was NOT a feature of the Napoleonic Code of 1804?
   (a) Equality before the law (b) Right to property (c) Restoration of privileges based on birth (d) Abolition of the feudal system
2. The Zollverein formed in 1834 at the initiative of Prussia was a
   (a) customs union (b) secret revolutionary society (c) parliament of German states (d) treaty with Austria
3. Who hosted the Congress of Vienna in 1815?
   (a) Otto von Bismarck (b) Count Cavour (c) Napoleon (d) Duke Metternich
4. Giuseppe Garibaldi is best known for
   (a) founding Young Europe in Berne (b) leading the Red Shirts into the Kingdom of the Two Sicilies (c) drafting the Frankfurt constitution (d) the Act of Union of 1707
5. In Philip Veit's Germania, the crown of oak leaves stands for
   (a) readiness to fight (b) willingness to make peace (c) heroism (d) being freed
6. Greece was recognised as an independent nation by the
   (a) Treaty of Vienna, 1815 (b) Act of Union, 1707 (c) Treaty of Versailles, 1919 (d) Treaty of Constantinople, 1832
7. Why were the Balkans called a "powder keg"?
   (a) They had large gunpowder factories (b) Ottoman decline, rival Slav nationalisms and big-power rivalry made the region explosive (c) They were the centre of the French Revolution (d) Bismarck fought all his wars there
8. Describe any three measures taken by the French revolutionaries to create a sense of collective identity among the French people.
9. Explain the process of unification of Germany.

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. d 4. b 5. c 6. d 7. b 8. see notes 9. see notes